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Padmanabhaswamy Temple

The **Padmanabhaswamy Temple** (Malayalam: [pɐd̪mɐnaːbʰɐswaːmi]) is a Hindu temple dedicated to Vishnu in Thiruvananthapuram, the capital of the state of Kerala, India. It is one of the 108 Divya Desams that are considered among the most sacred abodes of Vishnu in the Sri Vaishnava tradition. Adi Shankara had composed sacred hymns on AnanthaPadmanabha and it is an important holy site for Smartha Tradition. The name of the city it stands on, Thiruvananthapuram, in Malayalam and Tamil translates to "The City of Ananta" (Ananta being a form of Vishnu).[1] The temple is built in an intricate fusion of the Kerala style and the Dravidian style of architecture, featuring high walls, and a 16th-century gopuram.[2][3] While as per some traditions the Ananthapura Temple in Kumbla in Kerala's Kasaragod district is considered as the original spiritual seat of the deity ("Mulasthanam"), architecturally to some extent, the temple is a replica of the Adikesava Perumal Temple in Thiruvattar in Kanyakumari district of Tamil Nadu.[4]

The principal deity is Padmanabhaswamy (Sanskrit: पद्मनाभस्वामि, IAST: *Padmanābhasvāmi*), a form of Vishnu enshrined in the "Anantashayana" posture, engaged in eternal yogic sleep on his serpent mount named Shesha.[5] Padmanabhaswamy is the tutelary deity of the Travancore royal family. The titular Maharaja of Travancore, Moolam Thirunal Rama Varma, is the current trustee of the temple.

Padmanabhaswamy Temple	
Entrance of the Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple	
Religion	
Affiliation	Hinduism
District	Thiruvananthapuram District
Deity	Vishnu and Lakshmi
Governing body	Travancore royal family
Location	
Location	Thiruvananthapuram
State	Kerala
Country	India

History

Several extant Hindu texts including the Vishnu Purana,[6] Brahma Purana,[7] Matsya Purana,[8] Varaha Purana,[8] Skanda Purana,[7] Padma Purana,[7] Vayu Purana, Bhagavata Purana and Mahabharata mention the Padmanabhaswamy Temple.[7] The Temple has been referred to in the (only recorded) Sangam period literature several times.[9] Many conventional historians and scholars are of the opinion that one of

the names that the Temple had, "The Golden Temple", was in cognisance of the Temple being already unimaginably wealthy by that point (early Sangam period).[10][11][9] Many extant pieces of Sangam Tamil literature and poetry as well as later works of the 9th century of Tamil poet–saints like Nammalwar refer to the temple and the city as having walls of pure gold.[12] Both the temple and the entire city are often eulogised as being made of gold and the temple as heaven.[12][13]

The temple is one of the 108 principal Divya Desams ("Holy Abodes") in Vaishnavism according to existing Tamil hymns from the seventh and eighth centuries C.E and is glorified in the *Divya Prabandha*. The *Divya Prabandha* glorifies this shrine as being among the 13 Divya Desam in Malai Nadu (corresponding to present-day Kerala with Kanyakumari District).[14] Nammalwar sang the glories of Padmanabha.

It is believed that Parasurama purified and venerated the idol of Sree Padmanabhaswamy in *Dvapara Yuga*. Parasurama entrusted 'Kshethra karyam' (Administration of the Temple) to seven Potti families – Koopakkara Potti, Vanchiyoor Athiyara Potti, Kollur Athiyara Potti, Muttavila Potti, Karuva Potti, Neythasseri Potti and Sreekaryathu Potti. King Adithya Vikrama of Vanchi (Venad) was directed by Parasurama to do 'Paripalanam' (Protection) of the Temple. Parasurama gave the Tantram of the Temple to Tharananallur Namboothiripad. This legend is narrated in detail in the Kerala Mahathmyam which forms part of the Brahmanda Puranam.

Another version regarding the consecration of the principal idol of the Temple relates to the legendary sage Vilvamangalathu Swamiyar. Swamiyar, who resided near Ananthapuram Temple in Kasaragod District, prayed to Vishnu for his *darshan* or "auspicious sight". The deity is believed to have come to Swamiyar in the guise of a little boy who was mischievous and charming. The devout sage wished that the boy stay with him. The boy agreed upon the condition that He be treated with the utmost respect, and if that promise were to ever be broken, the boy would immediately vanish. But soon his antics became unbearable for the sage, he reacted furiously. the boy

Padmanabhaswamy Temple (Kerala)

Padmanabhaswamy Temple (India)

Padmanabhaswamy Temple (Asia)

Coordinates 8°28′58″N 76°56′37″E

Architecture

disappeared from there. [15] Realising the boy was no ordinary mortal, the sage wept for forgivenes. He heard a voice say "If you want to see me come to the Ananthavanam (the unending forest or Ananthankadu). After a long search, when he was walking on the banks of the Laccadive Sea, heard a *pulaya* lady Scolding her child that "If you cry any more, I will throw you into Ananthankadu."

Type	Fusion of Kerala architecture and Tamil architecture
Website	
spstt.org (https://spstt.org/) spst.in (https://spst.in/)	

Gopuram of the Padmanabhaswamy Temple

The moment the Swami heard the word Ananthankadu he was delighted. He proceeded to Ananthankadu based on the directions of the lady and reached Ananthankadu. There he saw the child merging into an ilippa tree (Indian butter tree , Scientific Name: Madhuca longifolia). Soon the tree fell down and Ananta Padmanabhaswami (Lord Vishnu, is reclining on the celestial snake Anantha) appeared. But figure of the deity was extraordinarily large size, with His head at Thiruvattar near Thuckalay Tamil Nadu, body (udal) at Thiruvananthapuram, and his feet at Thrippadapuram (Thrippappur) near Kulathoor and Technopark

The figure was about eight miles long. So he could not see it completely. The sage requested the Lord to shrink in a proportion that would be thrice the length of his staff. Immediately the deity shrank to the form of the idol that is seen at present in the Temple. Even then many iluppa trees obstructed a complete view of the deity. The sage saw the deity in three parts – thirumukham, thiruvudal and thrippadam. The swami prayed to Padmanabha to be forgiven. He offered rice *kanji* and *uppu manga* (salted mango pieces) in a coconut shell to the Perumal which he obtained from the pulaya woman. The spot where the sage had darsan of the deity belonged to Koopakkara Potti and Karuva Potti. With the assistance of the reigning King and some Brahmin households a temple was constructed.[16] The Ananthankadu Nagaraja Temple still exists to the northwest of the Padmanabhaswamy Temple. The samadhi (final resting place) of the *swamiyar* is to the west of the Padmanabhaswamy Temple. A Krishna temple was built over the samadhi. This temple, known as Vilvamangalam Sri Krishna Swami Temple, belongs to Thrissur Naduvil Madhom.[4]

Mukilan, a Muslim marauder, invaded vast chunks of Venad in 1680 AD.[17] He destroyed Budhapuram Bhaktadasa Perumal Temple owned by Neythasseri Potti. Mukilan intended to plunder Padmanabhaswamy Temple and destroy it. But he was dissuaded from doing so by local Muslims loyal to the royals of Venad. Padmanabhan Thampi, arch rival of Anizham Thirunal Marthanda Varma, marched to Thiruvananthapuram with his forces and tried to loot the Temple. Thampi stayed at Sri Varaham and sent his mercenaries to Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple. It is said that divine serpents materialised in hundreds and scared away Thampi's men. Emboldened by this divine intervention, Pallichal Pillai and local people opposed Padmanabhan Thampi, and ensured that the mercenaries did not proceed with the misdeed.

Extant temple records

A pertinent event in the long history of the temple was the construction of a "granta-pura" (record-room) within the temple compound itself around 1425 A.D. by the then Venad King Veera Iravi Iravi Varma, to store the "Mathilakam" (within-the-walls) records, as the then existing temple records were known.[18] A major portion of those records (over 3000 'Cadjan' leaf-records) from the Mathikalam had been donated later to the Archives Department in 1867 at the time of the formation of the latter. Each of these Cadjan leaf-records, which have been compiled over thousands of years, contains 10,000 documentations according to R. Nagaswamy, noted archaeologist and historian, totalling over 30 crores of records. Despite their cultural value, only a minuscule portion of these grantas (bundles) of cadjan leaf records, written mostly in ancient scripts of proto-Tamil and archaic-Malayalam, have been deciphered. The translations of this section of manuscripts by some scholars serve as a rare though very inadequate primary source material on the temple and its rich traditions.

The rest of these Mathilakam documents – segregated under 70 "heads" – is still lying idle with the Archives Department. According to Aswathi Thirunal Gouri Lakshmi Bayi, a member of the Travancore Royal Family and author of a book on the temple, from a very early period in recorded history the temple had employed two kinds of 'record writers'. One group was to record the proceedings and transactions of the Ettarayogam, a council of temple administrators, that included the then king. The other was to write and preserve the records of the day-to-day functioning of the temple, maintain correct accounts of the temple-treasury, and of temple-revenue-collections and of temple-expenditure, as well as to note down all the other records connected with the functioning of the temple.

Travancore royal family

In the first half of the 18th century, in line with matrilineal customs, Anizham Thirunal Marthanda Varma, succeeded his uncle Rama Varma as king at the age of 23. He successfully suppressed the 700-year-old stranglehold of the Ettuveetil Pillamar ("Lords of the Eight Houses") and his cousins following the discovery of conspiracies which the lords were involved in against the royal house of Travancore (There are various legends and disputes about these mostly apocryphal stories, but overall, he took control and centralised the rule). The last major renovation of the Padmanabhaswamy temple commenced immediately after Anizham Thirunal's accession to the throne and the idol was reconsecrated in 906 ME (1731 CE). On 17 January 1750, Anizham Thirunal surrendered the Kingdom of Travancore to Padmanabhaswamy, the main deity at the temple, and pledged that he and his descendants would be vassals or agents of the deity who would serve the kingdom as *Padmanabha Dasa*.[5] Since then, the name of every Travancore king was preceded by the title 'Sree Padmanabha Dasa'; the female members of the royal family were called 'Sree Padmanabha Sevini' both meaning the servant to Padmanabhaswamy. The donation of the king to Padmanabhaswamy was known as Thrippadi-danam. The final wishes of Anizham Thirunal on his passing at the age of 53 clearly delineated the historical relationship between the Maharaja and the temple: "That no deviation whatsoever should be made in regard to the dedication of the kingdom to Padmanabhaswamy and that all future territorial acquisitions should be made over to the Devaswom."

Temple structure

Main shrine

Interior of the Padmanabhaswamy Temple

In the *Garbhagriha*, Padmanabha reclines on the serpent *Anantha* or *Adi Sesha*.[19] The serpent has five hoods facing inwards, signifying contemplation. The deity's right hand is placed over a Shiva lingam. Sridevi-Lakshmi, the Goddess of Prosperity and Bhudevi the Goddess of Earth, two consorts of Vishnu, are by his side. Brahma emerges on a lotus, which emanates from the navel of the deity. The deity is made from 12,008 saligramams.[20] These saligrams are from the banks of the Gandaki River in Nepal, and to commemorate this, certain rituals used to be performed at the Pashupatinath Temple.[21] The "Katusarkara yogam" idol of the deity is covered with a special ayurvedic mix which is made of 108 natural materials collected from all over India and forms a protective layer that keeps the deity clean.

The platforms in front of the vimanam and where the deity rests are both carved out of a single massive stone and hence called "Ottakkal-mandapam". On the orders of Marthanda Varma (1706–58), the Ottakkal-mandapam was cut out of a rock at Thirumala, about 4 miles (6.4 km) north of the temple. It measured 20 square feet (1.9 m^2; 190 dm^2; 19,000 cm^2) in area by 2.5 feet (30 in; 7.6 dm; 76 cm) thick and was placed in front of the deity in the month of Edavom 906 M.E. (1731 CE). At the same time, Marthanda Varma also brought 12,000 shaligrams, aniconic representations of Vishnu, from the Gandaki River, north of Benares (now known as Varanasi) to the temple. These were used in the reconsecration of Padmanabha.[22]

To perform darshan and puja, devotees have to ascend to the mandapam. The deity is visible through three doors – the visage of the reclining Padmanabha and Siva Linga underneath his hand is seen through the first door; Sridevi and Bhrigu Muni in Katusarkara, Brahma seated on a lotus emanating from the deity's navel, hence the name, "Padmanabha", gold abhisheka moorthies of Padmanabha, Sridevi and Bhudevi, and silver utsava moorthi of Padmanabha through the second door; the deity's feet, and Bhudevi and Markandeya Muni in Katusarkara through the third door. The idols of two goddesses holding chamaram, Garuda, Narada, Tumburu, the divine forms of the six weapons of Vishnu, Surya, Chandra, the Saptarshi, Madhu, and Kaitabha are also in the Sanctum. Only the King of Travancore may prostrate on the "Ottakkal-mandapam". It is traditionally held that anybody who prostrates on the mandapam has surrendered all that he possesses to the deity. Since the ruler has already done that, he is permitted to prostrate on this mandapam.[23]

Other shrines

Inside the Temple, there are two other important shrines, Thekkedom and Thiruvambadi, for the deities Ugra Narasimha and Krishna Swami, respectively.

Centuries ago, several families of Vrishni Kshatriyas travelled to the south, carrying with them idols of Balarama and Krishna. When they reached the hallowed land of Sree Padmanabha, they gave the idol of Balarama, also known as Bhaktadasa, to Neythasseri Potti. Neythasseri Potti built a Temple for this idol at Budhapuram, a place sanctified by the penance of Budha and the presence of Goddess Madhu Kaitabha Nasini (Mahakali). The Vrishnis gifted the idol of Krishna to Maharaja Udaya Marthanda Varma of Venad. The Maharaja constructed a separate shrine, known as Thiruvambadi, in the premises of Padmanabhaswamy Temple for this idol. The Thiruvambadi shrine enjoys an independent status. Thiruvambadi has its own namaskara mandapam, bali stones and flagmast. The deity of Thiruvambadi is Parthasarathi, the Divine Charioteer of Arjuna, who is the warrior prince and one of the main protagonists that appear in the epic of Mahabharata. The two-armed granite idol, with one hand holding the whip and the other resting on the left thigh holding the conch close to it, is in standing posture. On Ekadashi days, the deity is dressed and adorned as Mohini. The Vrishnis who came to Venad and settled there are known as Krishnan Vakakkar as they belong to the lineage of Krishna.

There are also shrines for Rama accompanied by his wife Sita, half-brother Lakshmana, Hanuman, Vishvaksena (the Nirmalyadhari of Vishnu and Remover of Obstacles), Vyasa and Ashwatthama the Chiranjivis, Ganapati, Sasta, and Kshetrapala (who guards the temple). Grand idols of Garuda and Hanuman stand with folded hands in the Valiya balikkal area.[4]

Gopuram

The foundation of the present gopuram was laid in 1566.[24] The temple has a 100-foot (30 m) high[25] 7-tier gopuram built in the Pandyan style.[26] The temple stands by the side of a tank, named *Padma Theertham* (meaning the lotus spring). The temple has a corridor with 365 and one-quarter sculptured granite-stone pillars with elaborate carvings which stands out to be an ultimate testimonial for the Vishvakarma sthapathis in sculpting this architectural masterpiece. This corridor extends from the eastern side into the sanctum sanctorum. An 80-foot (24 m) flagstaff stands in front of the main entry from the *prakaram* (closed precincts of a temple).

Temple rituals

Festivals and rites

There are many festivals associated with this temple. The major festivals are bi-annual. The *Aipasi* festival and the *Panguni* festival in the Tamil month of aipasi (October/November) and Panguni (March/April) respectively, last for 10 days each. On the ninth day the Maharajah of Travancore, in his capacity as Thrippappoor Mooppan, escorts the deities to the vettakkalam for Pallivetta. Centuries ago, the Pallivetta procession was said to pass through Kaithamukku, Kuthiravattom (Kunnumpuram), Pazhaya Sreekanteswaram and Putharikkandam. The festivals culminate with the *Aarat* (holy bath) procession to the Shankumugham Beach. The word *Aarat* refers to the purifying immersion of the deities of the temple in sea. This event takes place in the evening. The Maharajah of Travancore escorts the *Aarat* procession on foot. The festival idols, or "Utsava Vigrahas", of Padmanabhaswamy, Narasimha Moorthi and Krishna Swami are given a ritual bath in the sea, after the prescribed pujas. After this ceremony, the idols are taken back to the temple in a procession that is lit by traditional torches, marking the conclusion of the festival.[4]

A major annual festival related to Padmanabhaswamy temple is the *Navaratri* festival. The idols of Saraswati Amman, Mun Uditha Nangai (**Parasakti**, who appeared before Saraswati, Lakshmi and Parvati to help them identify their husbands who had been transformed into infants by the power of chastity of Anasuya) and Kumara Swami (Murugan) are brought from the Padmanabhapuram Palace, Suchindram, and Kumarakovil respectively to the *Kuthira malika* palace in front of Padmanabhaswamy temple as a procession. This festival lasts for 9 days. The famous Swathi Sangeethotsavam music festival is held every year during this festival in the *Navratri* mandapam and in some other surrounding temples. The festival was named in honour of the Maharajah of Travancore, Swathi Thirunal Rama Varma and is organized by his descendant in the Royal Family, Prince Rama Varma.

Narasimha Swamy and Padmanabha Swamy after coming from Shankumugham Beach during Aarat Festival

The biggest festival in this temple is *laksha deepam* which means one lakh lamps. This festival is observed once in 6 years. Prior to this festival, chanting of prayers and recitation of three vedas is done for 56 days (Murajapam). On the last day, one lakh oil lamps are lit in and around the temple premises.

Big idol of Pandava displayed during Panguni festival

Priests

Temples where 'Swamiyar Pushpanjali' is conducted are claimants to extra sanctity. Sannyasins from Naduvil Madhom and Munchira Madhom perform Pushpanjali (flower worship) daily to Padmanabha, Narasimha Moorthi and Krishna Swami. Tharananallur Nambuthiripads of Iranjalakkuda are the Tantris of the Temple. The Nambis, altogether four in number, are the Chief Priests of the Temple. Two Nambis – Periya Nambi and Panchagavyathu Nambi – are allotted to Padmanabha and one Nambi each to Narasimha Moorthi and Krishna Swami. The Nambis hail from either side of the Chandragiri River.[4]

Temple entry

In line with the Temple Entry Proclamation, only those who profess the Hindu faith are permitted entry to the temple and devotees have to strictly follow the dress code.[27] Men wear "vesti" with "angavastram" (the South Indian version of dhoti and shawl, both plain white in color) and women wear sari.

Temple management

The Padmanabhaswamy Temple and its property were controlled by the Ettara Yogam (King and Council of Eight) with the assistance of Ettuveetil Pillamar ("Lords of the Eight Houses"). The Ettara Yogam consists of the Pushpanjali Swamiyar, the six member Thiruvananthapurathu Sabha, the Sabhanjithan (Secretary) and the Arachan (Maharaja of Travancore). The Thiruvananthapurathu Sabha was primarily

responsible for the administration of the Temple. Koopakkara Potti, Vanchiyoor Athiyara Potti, Kollur Athiyara Potti, Muttavila Potti, Karuva Potti and Neythasseri Potti are the members of the Sabha. The Pushpanjali Swamiyar presides over the meetings of the Sabha. Sreekaryathu Potti is the Sabhanjithan of the Sabha.[28] Any decision taken by the Sabha can be implemented only if the Maharaja of Travancore approves of it.[29] It is believed that eight members of Ettara Yogam (seven Potties and the Maharaja of Travancore) received their rights from Parashurama Himself.

The approach road to the Padmanabhaswamy Temple

In the past, only the Swamiyars of the Naduvil Madhom were appointed as Pushpanjali Swamiyars by the Maharaja of Travancore. Anizham Thirunal Marthanda Varma curtailed the authority of Ettara Yogam and liquidated the powerful Ettuveetil Pillamar. Ettara Yogam became an advisory and assenting body thereafter. Besides the Naduvil Madhom, the Munchira Madhom got the right to appoint Pushpanjali Swamiyars during his reign. In the recent past, Uthradom Thirunal Marthanda Varma gave Pushpanjali rights to the Swamiyars of Thrikkaikattu Madhom and Thekke Madhom as well. Though the Maharaja is the appointing authority of the Pushpanjali Swamiyar, the former must do a Vechu Namaskaram when he sees the Swamiyar. With the passing away of Uthradom Thirunal Marthanda Varma in December 2013, his nephew Moolam Thirunal Rama Varma became the titular Maharaja of Travancore in January 2014. Like his predecessors, Moolam Thirunal also got concurrence from the Ettara Yogam before assuming the title 'Maharaja'. In the presence of the Maharaja designate, the Yogathil Pottimar and the Tantri, the Pushpanjali Swamiyar Maravanchery Thekkedathu Neelakanta Bharatikal signed on the Neettu (Order) of the Ettara Yogam accepting Moolam Thirunal as *Chirava Mootha Thiruvadi* (Maharaja of Travancore) and *Thrippappoor Mootha Thiruvadi* (Protector of the Temple). This ceremony took place at Kulasekhara Mandapam in Padmanabhaswamy Temple. Revathi Thirunal Balagopal Varma, grandson of Maharani Regent Pooradom Thirunal Sethu Lakshmi Bayi, is the titular Elayaraja of Travancore.

Temple assets

The temple and its assets belong to the deity, Lord Padmanabhaswamy, and since a long time, have been controlled by a trust headed by the Travancore royal family. T P Sundararajan's litigation changed the way the world looked at the Temple.[30][31][32][33]

The temple and its tank

Vault (Nilavara) B ("The Forbidden Zone")

The Vault B, its original name being "Mahabharata Kallara", is by far the largest cellar.[34][13] The Bhagavata Purana says that Balarama visited Phalgunam (now known as Thiruvananthapuram), took bath in Panchapsaras (Padmateertham) and made a gift of ten thousand cows to holy men.[35] Though the sannidhyam of Padmanabha has always been present in the holy land of Thiruvananthapuram, and it was a very ancient and renowned pilgrim spot even during the time of Balarama, the present-day temple for the deity came up later. The southwest part of the

Chuttambalam was constructed at the holy spot where Balarama is believed to have donated the cows. This portion came to be known as Mahabharatakonam and covered the ground underneath where both Kallara B and Kallara A were situated.[36]

According to a popular legend, many gods and sages devoted to Balarama visited him on the banks of Padmateertham. They requested that they be permitted to reside there worshipping the lord. Balarama granted them their wish. It is believed that these devas and sages reside in Kallara B worshipping the deity. Naga Devathas devoted to the deity also dwell in this Kallara.[37] Kanjirottu Yakshi, whose enchanting and ferocious forms are painted on the south-west part of the main Sanctum, resides in this Kallara worshipping Narasimha.[38] Holy objects like Sreechakram were installed beneath this Kallara to enhance the potency of the principal deity. Ugra Narasimha of Thekkedom is said to be the Protector of Kallara B. There is a serpent's image on Kallara B indicating danger to anyone who opens it. A four-day Ashtamangala Devaprasnam conducted in August 2011 declared Kallara B as a "forbidden zone".[39]

One of the oldest existing estimates concerning only Vault B, as per the Temple priests, was by the Travancore Royal Family themselves in the 1880s (when an older existing inventory and estimate were last updated). Then, the gold in Vault B which is by far the largest and the only vault (of the reported six) that is unopened so far since the 1880s, was worth INR 12,000 Crores in the then (1880s') terms.[34][40] The price of gold in the 1880s, when the inventory and estimate were last updated, was INR 1.8 per gram. (The price of gold was about US$18 for an ounce in the 1880s when the dollar was 3.3 to the rupee.)[41]

It is highly unlikely that Kallara B was opened after the 1880s. An article by Emily Gilchriest Hatch,[42] a visiting Englishwoman in 1933, recalls in her book 'Travancore: A Guide Book for the Visitor' (Oxford University Press, 1933) about an unsuccessful attempt to open one Kallara in 1908: "About 25 years ago, when the State needed additional money, it was thought expedient to open these chests and use the wealth they contained." "A group of people" got together and attempted to enter the vaults with torches. When they found the vaults "infested with cobras" they "fled for their lives."[13]

The royal family has also claimed that opening Vault B could be a bad omen.[43] The seven-member team were to consult with some more experts on 8 July 2011, and make a final decision on opening the chamber.[44] An Ashtamangala Devaprasnam conducted in the Temple to discern the will of the deity revealed that any attempts to open chamber B would cause divine displeasure, and that the holy articles in the other chambers were defiled in the inventorying process.[21] In 2011, the antechamber to Kallara B was opened by the Observers appointed by the Supreme Court of India.[45] But the Observers could not open Kallara B. However, Gopal Subramanium in his report submitted to the Supreme Court in April 2014, recommended its opening after conducting another Devaprasnam. The two Pushpanjali Swamiyars are the highest spiritual dignitaries of Padmanabhaswamy Temple. The Pushpanjali Swamiyar of Naduvil Madhom sent letters to the Chairperson of the Administrative Committee and the Executive Officer on 8 February 2016 expressing his strong opposition to the opening of Kallara B.[46] The Pushpanjali Swamiyar of Munchira Madhom led a Ratha Yathra from Kasaragod to Thiruvananthapuram in May 2018 campaigning against opening the sacred Kallara. Azhvanchery Thamprakkal, the supreme spiritual leader of Kerala Brahmins, while addressing a meeting held in connection with the Ratha Yathra, also demanded that faith should not be trampled upon by opening Kallara B.[47]

According to a report by former Comptroller and Auditor General of India Vinod Rai, at least the outer door (antechamber) to Kallara B has been opened a number of times in recent decades - twice in 1991 and five times in 2002. Once Vinod Rai's report was out, Princess Aswathi Thirunal Gowri Lakshmi Bayi

clarified that Mr Rai was referring to the antechamber to Kallara B, and that that antechamber was opened even in 2011 by the Supreme Court-appointed observers.[48]

Opening of the five smaller vaults in July 2011 till Supreme Court Final Judgment in July 2020

In June 2011, the Supreme Court of India directed the authorities from the archaeology department and the fire services to open the secret chambers of the temple for inspection of the items kept inside.[49] The temple has six hitherto known vaults (nilavaras), labelled as A to F, for bookkeeping purpose by the Court. (Since then, however, an Amicus Curie Report by Gopal Subramanium, in April 2014, reportedly found two more further subterranean vaults that have been named G and H.) While vault B has been unopened over centuries, A was possibly opened in the 1930s, and vaults C to F have been opened from time to time over recent years. The two priests of the temple, the 'Periya Nambi' and the 'Thekkedathu Nambi', are the custodians of the four vaults, C to F, which are opened periodically. The Supreme Court had directed that "the existing practices, procedures, and rituals" of the temple be followed while opening vaults C to F and using the articles inside, while Vaults A and B would be opened only for the purpose of making an inventory of the articles and then closed. The review of the temple's underground vaults was undertaken by a seven-member panel appointed by the Supreme Court to generate an inventory, leading to the enumeration of a vast collection of articles that are traditionally kept under lock and key. A detailed inventory of the temple assets, consisting of gold, jewels, and other valuables is yet to be made.

While vault B (as also presumably Vault G and Vault H) remains unopened (since the 1880s), vaults A, C, D, E and F were opened along with some of their antechambers. Among the reported findings, is a 1.1 metres (3.5 ft) tall solid pure golden idol of Mahavishnu, studded with hundreds of diamonds and rubies and other precious stones.[50] Also found were an 5.5-metre (18 ft)-long pure gold chain, a gold sheaf weighing 500 kg (1,100 lb), a 36 kg (79 lb) golden veil, 1200 'Sarappalli' gold coin-chains that are encrusted with precious stones, and several sacks filled with golden artefacts, necklaces, diadems, diamonds, rubies, sapphires, emeralds, gemstones, and objects made of other precious metals.[51][52][53][54] Ceremonial attire for adorning the deity in the form of 16-part gold anki weighing almost 30 kilograms (66 lb), gold "coconut shells" studded with rubies and emeralds, and several 18th century Napoleonic era coins were found amongst many other objects.[3] In early 2012, an expert committee had been appointed to investigate these objects, which include lakhs of golden coins of the Roman Empire, that were found in Kottayam, in Kannur District.[55][56] According to Vinod Rai, the former Comptroller-and-Auditor-General (CAG) of India, who had audited some of the Temple records from 1990, in August 2014, in the already opened vault A, there is an 800 kg (1,800 lb) hoard of gold coins dating to around 200 BCE, each coin priced at over ₹2.7 crore (US$320,000).[57] Also found was a pure golden throne, studded with hundreds of diamonds and other precious stones, meant for the 5.5-metre (18 ft)-long deity. According to one of the men who entered Vault A, several of the largest diamonds were as large as a full-grown man's thumb.[58] According to varying reports, at least three, if not more, solid gold crowns have been found, studded with diamonds and other precious stones.[59][60][61] Some media reports also mention hundreds of pure gold chairs, thousands of gold pots and jars, among the articles recovered from Vault A and its antechambers.[62]

Even with only the five smaller of the reported eight vaults being opened (the larger three vaults and all their ante-chambers still remaining closed), the treasure found so far is considered to be by far the largest collection of items of gold and fully precious stones in the recorded history of the world.[63][64]

The valuables are believed to have been accumulated in the temple over several thousand years, having been donated to the deity (and subsequently stored there), by various dynasties like the Cheras, the Pandyas, the Travancore Royal Family, the Kolathiris, the Pallavas, the Cholas and many other kings of both South India and beyond, and from the rulers and traders of Mesopotamia, Jerusalem, Greece, Rome, and later, the various colonial powers from Europe, and other countries as well.[10][11][9][65] Some people have suggested that a part of the stored riches reached the Travancore kings in the later years in the form of tax as well as conquered wealth of other South Indian kingdoms.[66] Most scholars however believe that this was accumulated over thousands of years, given the mention of the deity and the Temple in several extant Hindu Texts, the Sangam Tamil literature (500 BC to 300 AD wherein it was referred to as the "Golden Temple" on account of its then unimaginable wealth), and the treasures consist of countless artefacts dating back to the Chera, Pandya, Greek, and Roman epochs. The ancient late-Tamil-Sangam epic Silappatikaram (c 100 AD to 300 AD at the latest) speaks of the then Chera King Cenkuttuvan receiving gifts of gold and precious stones from a certain 'Golden Temple' (Arituyil-Amardon) which is believed to be the Padmanabhaswamy Temple.[67][68][69]:65[69]:73[70] Gold had been panned from rivers as well as mined in Thiruvananthapuram, Kannur, Wayanad, Kollam, Palakkad and Malappuram districts for thousands of years. The Malabar region (as a part of the "Tamilakam" region of recorded history) had several centers of trade and commerce since the Sumerian period ranging from Vizhinjam in the south to Mangalore in the north. Also, at times like the invasion by Mysore in the late 1700s, the other related royal families (of the Travancore Royal Family) in Kerala and the far south, like the Kolathiris, took refuge in Thiruvananthapuram and stored their temple-wealth for safekeeping in the Padmanabhaswamy Temple.[10][11][9][18][71] Also, much of the treasure housed in the much larger and as-yet-unopened vaults, as well as in the much smaller cellars that have been opened, date back to long before the institution of the so-called Travancore Kingdom, e.g. the 800 kg (1,800 lb) hoard of gold coins from 200 B.C that was mentioned by Vinod Rai. Noted archaeologist and historian R. Nagaswamy has also stated that several records exist in Kerala, of offerings made to the deity, from several parts of Kerala.[10] Lastly, it has to be remembered that in the Travancore Kingdom, a distinction was always made between the Government (State) Treasury (Karuvelam), the Royal Family Treasury (Chellam), and the Temple Treasury (Thiruvara Bhandaram or Sri Bhandaram). During the reign of Maharani Gowri Lakshmi Bayi, hundreds of temples that were mismanaged in the Kerala region, were brought under the Government. The excess ornaments in these temples were also transferred to the Vaults of the Padmanabhaswamy Temple while the funds of the Padmanabhaswamy Temple were utilised for the daily upkeep of these temples.

The original petitioner (T. P. Sundarajan), whose court action led to the inventory, died in July 2011, adding credence to the folklore around the temple.[72] Prior to this now-famous incident in July 2011, one of the several vaults in the temple which was not vaults B (untouched after the 1880s), G, or H (both rediscovered supposedly by the Amicus Curie only in mid-2014), was opened in 1931. This was possibly an antechamber of vaults A, C, D, E, or F that may not have been opened yet. This was necessitated due to the severe economic depression that India was going through. The Palace and State Treasuries had run almost dry. The small group of people, including the king and the priests, found a granary-sized structure almost full with mostly gold and some silver coins and jewels. Surmounted on top of it were hundreds of pure gold pots. There were four coffers filled with gold coins as well. Also found was a larger chest fixed to the ground with six sections in it. They were full of gold jewelry encrusted with diamonds, rubies, sapphires, and emeralds. Besides these, there were four more chests of old coins (not of gold), and they were carried back to the Palace and state treasuries for counting.[13]

Litigations

The Kerala High Court ruled in 2011 that the state government should take over the control of the temple and its assets, but the Travancore royal family appealed to the Supreme Court.[73] An independent report was commissioned, and was completed in November 2012,[74] finding no evidence that the royal family were expropriating the treasures.[73]

As of April 2016, vaults B, G, and H along with their several ante-chambers were yet to be opened; while inventorying of the items in vaults C, D, E, and F were completed (in August 2012) and formal inventorying of vault A had commenced.[75] Several hundred pots and other items made of gold, that are used for daily rituals or intermittently for ceremonies in the Temple, were not inventoried as the Temple-priests expressed strong objections.[75] Over 1.02 lakh "articles" had been retrieved from Vault A and its ante-chambers, until that point, though only a small part of them had been inventoried then. An "article" could be either an individual item, or collections of several items, examples of the latter being a cache of 1.95 lakh 'Rassappanams' (Gold coins) weighing 800 kg and sets of Navaratnas (collections of nine different kinds of gems).[76] There are over 60,000 fully precious stones set as parts of larger pieces of gold jewellery among those items inventoried as of March 2013.[76] The results of the inventory are not to be released until the completion of the whole process by order of the Supreme Court of India.[74]

In April 2014, Amicus Curiae advocate Gopal Subramanium filed a 577-page report to the Supreme court of India alleging malpractices in the administration of the temple. According to him, the authorities failed to perform their ethical duties by opening many bank accounts, trusts and also not filing Income Tax returns for the past ten years. He alleged that Vault B was opened despite a previous ruling of the Supreme court prohibiting the same.[77]

The report states, "The large amount of gold and silver, the discovery of which was a shock to the Amicus Curiae, is a singular instance of mismanagement. The presence of a gold plating machine is also yet another unexplained circumstance. This discovery raises a doubt of the organized extraction by persons belonging to the highest echelons. There appears to be resistance on the part of the entire State apparatus in effectively addressing the said issues. The lack of adequate investigation by the police is a telling sign that although Thiruvananthapuram is a city in the State of Kerala, parallelism based on monarchic rule appears to predominate the social psyche."[78] The Supreme court bench comprising justice R. M. Lodha and justice A. K. Patnaik ordered a change in administration by forming a 5-member committee and appointing Vinod Rai as auditor. The committee will include Thiruvananthapuram District judge K. P. Indira,[79] Thantri and Nambi of the temple and two members to be decided in consultation with the Government of Kerala. Additionally, IAS officer and former administrator of the temple, K. N. Satish was appointed as executive officer.[80][81] The Government of Kerala agreed to comply with the Supreme court order.[82] Moolam Thirunal Rama Varma remains the trustee of the temple and still does the ritual duties as the titular Maharaja of Travancore, but has no responsibility regarding the temple management after the interim ruling by the Supreme Court[83][84] The report also found the existence of two more vaults that were never even made mention of or hitherto spoken about.

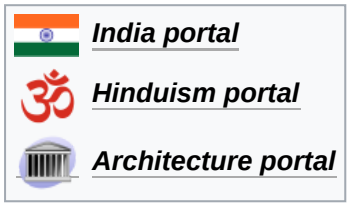
The report named them Vault 'G' and Vault 'H'. Like Vault 'B' and all its antechambers, both these vaults and their antechambers were yet to be opened as of May 2014.[85][86] The report also mentions that Mr. Subramanian found several large trunks filled with artefacts made of precious metals and precious stones outside of the eight vaults and their antechambers.[87]

The CBI and the Intelligence Bureau have red-flagged the appointment of Gopal Subramanium as a Judge in the Supreme Court. The IB cites Mr Subramaniam's report on Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple as one of the instances where he relied heavily on his spiritual instincts rather than rational logic and hard facts.[88] In his second report on Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple, Mr Subramaniam himself reveals that "It was his morning ritual of [shutting] his mind and seeking guidance, which resulted in discoveries in this direction."[89]

The Amicus Curiae has also been accused of conducting illegal poojas in the Temple in violation of its customs.[88] He performed poojas at the Thevarappura in the Temple and front of the Vedavyasa Shrine. Despite opposition from the Royal Family and the tantric priests of the Temple, he pulled out a stone Yantra from the nearby Marthandan Madhom Palace and did pooja on it for several days. The tantrics explained that the Yantram had no connection with the Padmanabhaswami Temple and that it was for the protection of the Palace. But the Amicus Curiae insisted on having it installed in the Sanctum Sanctorum of the Temple. Due to severe opposition from the Tantrics, the Yantram remains where it was. Every morning, Padmanabha is to be awakened only by blowing the conch shell and chanting the Sripada Sooktham. But the Amicus Curiae introduced the daily rendering of Venkatesa Suprabhatam to awaken the deity. The Supreme Court requested the Tantrics to take the final decision on whether the Suprabhatam could be sung. Following that, the Senior Tantric Nedumpilli Tharananalloor Parameswaran Namboothiripad directed the Temple authorities to stop the chanting of Suprabhatam forthwith, as it was causing 'Anya Mantra Yajana Dosham' (affliction due to worshipping the deity with incompatible mantras) to the presiding deity and the Temple. As atonement for this error, the Tantric wants Vedic scholars to chant 12 'muras' each of Rig Veda and Yajur Veda. In his first report to the Supreme Court, the Amicus Curiae directed the Tantries to examine whether a Sri Yantra can be installed in the Sanctum Sanctorum, in front of the processional idol.[90]

On 13 July 2020, overturning the January 2011 judgment of the Kerala high court, the Supreme Court of India ruled that the Padmanabhaswamy Temple administration and control would be, henceforth, in the hands of the erstwhile Travancore royal family.[91][92]

See also



- Padmanabhaswamy Temple treasure
- Thirumal in Thiruvananthapuram
- Temples of Kerala
- Attukal Temple
- Vellayani Devi Temple
- Methan mani, clock tower adjoining the temple

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